

MGTA 402 DATA DRIVEN COMMUNICATIONS

Fall 2026

CLASSROOM: 1E107

CLASS TIMES: November 4 – December 2 on Wednesdays 2:00-4:50 pm

INSTRUCTOR: Kim Walsh

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PHONE: 760-470-1497

OFFICE HOURS: Wednesdays 5:00-6:00, and by appt.

TEACHING ASSISTANT:

EMAIL:

DESCRIPTION

Communication skills in the 21st century are of utmost importance. A strong presentation requires skill in sharing your ideas with authenticity, clarity and passion. This course will focus on preparing presentations using clear, effective stories to support your data and to persuade your listeners to action.

Whether you are presenting to a large crowd or to an individual client, we will focus on communication skills needed to inspire your audience. Using some of the techniques that actors use in training, you will have the opportunity to develop your speaking skills, and to improve your ability to effectively connect with your audience.

This is a lab class that is highly participatory. Each week you will work on exercises to enhance your performance skills designed to help you give clear and compelling presentations. You will work individually and in groups. Each week you will have readings on relative topics, prepare presentations, provide written feedback to your peers and write self-reflections. You will have a final project presentation to prepare on a subject of your choice, which we will begin to work on class 2.

OBJECTIVES

At the successful completion of this course, you will gain:

- More access to sharing your true authentic self
- Ease of delivery when giving presentations
- Increased vocal range and flexibility
- Organizational skills to share your statistical findings in engaging ways
- Techniques for compelling storytelling
- Greater ability to engage, connect and motivate your audience

COURSE MATERIALS

Books available via RedShelf in Canvas and the UCSD Library

To access the UCSD library (<https://library.ucsd.edu>) from off campus you must first connect to VPN.

How to set up:

<https://library.ucsd.edu/computig-ad-technology/connect-from-off-campus/index.html>

1. *Lead with a Story*, by Paul Smith
Available online via UCSD Library:
https://search-library.ucsd.edu/permalink/01UCS_SDII/ld412s/alma991013164119706535
2. *Storytelling with Data*, by Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic
Available online via UCSD Library:
https://search-library.ucsd.edu/permalink/01UCS_SDI/1vtf07t/cdi_askewsholts_vlebooks_9781119621584
3. *Slide-ology: The Art and Science of Creating Great Presentations*, by Nancy Duarte
Available online via UCSD Library:
https://search-library.ucsd.edu/permalink/01UCS_SDI/1vtf07t/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_743450273
4. *The Power of Vulnerability*, Brene Brown, Ted Talk (video)
https://www.ted.com/talks/brene_brown_the_power_of_vulnerability?utm_campaign=tedsbread&utm_medium=referral&utm_source=tedcomshare

Articles:

1. The Science Behind Storytelling
2. Structure Your Presentation Like a Story

SCHEDULE, ASSIGNMENTS AND READINGS

Assignments are due the day before class at 11:59pm unless otherwise specified (details on Canvas)

Session & Date	Topic	Assignments & Activities	Presentations
Week 1 11/4	Why Stories?	Pre-course Questionnaire Read: <i>Lead with a Story</i>: Intro & Ch. 1 Why Tell Stories? Read: <i>Storytelling with Data</i>: Intro & Ch. 1 The Importance of Context Read Article: <i>The Science Behind Storytelling</i> The Power of Vulnerability What Makes a Thrilling Speaker? Presentation 1: Failure Story Reflection 1: Peer Feedback and Reflection	Failure Stories
Week 2 11/11	Building Stories	Brainstorming 2-3 Final Presentation ideas Significant Stories List Presentation 2: Story of Significance to connect Read: <i>Storytelling with Data</i>: Ch. 2 Choosing an Effective Visual, and pages 179-185: The Power of Repetition, Reverse Storyboarding Read: <i>Lead with a Story</i>: Ch 5 Make Recommendations Stick, and	Stories to connect

		Ch 7 Structure of a Story Due after class: Presentation subject and partner Reflection 2: Peer Feedback and Reflection	
Week 3 11/18	Structuring Stories	Sketching out your Visuals Read Article: <i>Structure Your Presentation Like a Story</i> Read: <i>Slide-ology</i>: p.2-7 Creating a New Slide Ideology p. 14-15 Responding to Audience Needs p. 19 Case Study: Rick Justice p. 88-107 Arranging Elements p. 212-213 Template Guidelines p. 222-223, 230-231 Interacting with Slides p.248-249 A Call to Relate Reflection 3: Reflection	Storyboarding in groups
Week 4 11/25	Design and Sharing Presentations	Read: <i>Storytelling with Data</i>: Chapter 3: Clutter is your enemy! Chapter 4: Focus Your Audience's Attention Chapter 5: Think Like a Designer Reflection 4: Peer Feedback and Reflection	Storytelling with Data Final Presentations Group 1
Week 5 12/2	Sharing Presentations	Reflection 5: Peer Feedback and Reflection	Storytelling with Data Final Presentations Group 2

***BOLD Assignments require reading and prep BEFORE class.**

GRADING POLICY

Your final grade will be determined by a combination of presentations, in-class engagement, participation, reflection and feedback. Weekly readings and assignments must be completed prior to the class that they are assigned. Pre-work assignments are due at 11:59 pm the day before each class. Late assignments will not be accepted for grade credit.

Learning Activity	Percentage
Class engagement, participation, peer feedback & reflection	40%
Individual & Group Assignments	60%

COURSE POLICIES

ATTENDANCE & PRESENCE: Due to the participatory nature of the class, as well as our short time together, it's very difficult to miss even one class. The expectation is that you will be at all 5 class meetings. If, however, you have an illness do not come to class and email me before class. Please make sure that you see a physician and get a Covid test before returning to class. **You are responsible for all material covered in class.**

Please show respect to your classmates by being completely present, by practicing **active listening** and by giving presenters your undivided attention. **Please keep phones on silent and put away for the duration of the class.** When working in groups please be professional and show respect to your partner. This means communicating in a timely manner, showing up to work sessions on time and respecting their boundaries as a person. Be the best group partner you could ever hope for!

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:

<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

COMMITMENT TOWARD AN INCLUSIVE LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

Names & Pronouns

UCSD recognizes the importance of a diverse student body, and we are committed to fostering equitable classroom environments. You are invited, if you wish, to tell us how you want to be referred to both in terms of your name and your pronouns (he/him, she/her, they/them, etc.). Once pronouns are established every effort should be made on the part of the Instructor, Students, and Guests to use the pronouns expressed. The pronouns someone indicates are not necessarily indicative of their gender identity. Additionally, how you identify in terms of your gender, race, class, sexuality, religion, and dis/ability, among all aspects of your identity, is your choice whether to disclose (e.g. should it come up in conversation about experiences and perspectives) and should be self identified, not presumed or imposed. <https://www.mypronouns.org>

Kumeyaay Land Acknowledgment

For millennia, the Kumeyaay people have been a part of this land. This land has nourished, healed, protected and embraced them for many generations in a relationship of balance and harmony. As members of the UC San Diego community we acknowledge this legacy. We promote this balance and harmony. We find inspiration from this land; the land of the Kumeyaay. We thank Michael Miskwish, a Kumeyaay historian and professor of our neighboring university, SDSU, for these words. To learn more about the practice of Land Acknowledgements, please visit this [document](#).

Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS)

First and foremost, you are a human being. There is nothing more important than your mental health.

CAPS has been an integral member of the UCSD community since the late 1960's.

CAPS is accredited by the International Association of Counseling Services (IACS). Their integrative and student-centered services are designed to support students towards their academic success and personal development and well-being. Students also consult with CAPS about a variety of more specific personal, academic and relationship problems.

No problem or concern is too big or small.

Hours: M-F 8am-4pm PT Phone: 858-534-3755 Galbraith Hall 190

Website: <https://caps.ucsd.edu>. **Crisis Counseling 24-Hours: 858-534-3755**

“People will forget what you said, people will forget what you did, but people will never forget how you made them feel.”

- **Maya Angelou**